

Research Clinical trials have shown that olive leaves lower blood pressure.

Self-help Uses Cradle cap, p. 318; Stretch marks, p. 317.

Ononis spinosa (Fabaceae) Spiny Restharrow

Description Spiny perennial with 3 small leaflets per leaf, bright pink, pea-like flowers, and small seed pods.

Habitat & Cultivation A relatively common European plant, spiny restharrow thrives in dry grassland and along roadsides.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Spiny restharrow root contains phenols, lectins, triterpenoids, and a volatile oil (comprising mainly trans-anethole). The volatile oil in the root is diuretic; the non-volatile oil content is antidiuretic. A decoction of the root has an antidiuretic effect, as the volatile oil is lost in the steam. If a diuretic is desired, the root is made into an infusion.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The root is used as a diuretic and to prevent kidney and bladder stones. It is of value in a range of urinary system problems, including stones, gout, and cystitis. For excess fluid retention, spiny restharrow is best taken as a short-term treatment, in the form of an infusion.

Operculina turpethum (Convolvulaceae)

Turpeth

Description Twining climber with white tuberous roots, hairy, oval leaves, white funnel-shaped flowers, and round fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to tropical India, turpeth is now found in tropical regions around the world. The root is unearthed throughout the year.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Turpeth root contains turpethin resin (approximately 4%) and a volatile oil.

History & Folklore Turpeth has been used for several thousand years as a purgative in Ayurvedic medicine.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Turpeth root is chiefly used in small doses to clear the bowels. It is sometimes known as "Indian jalap," and is used in much the same way as this plant (*Ipomoea purga*, p. 223), though its action is slower and less drastic. In Ayurvedic medicine, turpeth is prescribed with picrorrhiza (*Picrorrhiza kurroa*, p. 248) to treat jaundice.

Cautions Take only under professional supervision. Do not take during pregnancy.

Opuntia ficus-indica (Cactaceae) Prickly Pear

Description Perennial cactus growing to 10 ft (3 m). Has large spatula-shaped stems covered in clusters of spines, brilliant yellow flowers, and roundish purple fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Prickly pear is native to Mexico and naturalized in semitropical regions around the world. The fruit is harvested when ripe, the stems when required.

Parts Used Flowers, fruit, stems.

Constituents The fruit contains mucilage, sugars, vitamin C, and other fruit acids.

History & Folklore Prickly

pear fruit is used to make conserves and an alcoholic drink in Mexico. The split stems have been bound around injured limbs as a first-aid measure.

Medicinal Actions

& Uses Prickly pear flowers are astringent and reduce bleeding, and are used for problems of the gastrointestinal tract—particularly diarrhea, colitis, and irritable bowel syndrome. The flowers are also taken to treat an enlarged prostate gland. The fruit is nutritious.



Prickly pear fruit

Origanum majorana syn. Majorana hortensis (Lamiaceae)

Sweet Marjoram

Description Woody perennial herb growing to 20 in (50 cm). Has aromatic oval leaves and pinkish-white flowers emerging from the upper leaf axils.

Habitat & Cultivation Sweet marjoram is native to countries bordering the Mediterranean. It is much cultivated as a culinary herb, and for its essential oil.

Parts Used Aerial parts, essential oil.

Constituents Sweet marjoram contains about 3% volatile oil (comprising sabinene hydrate, sabinene, linalool, carvacrol, and other terpenes), flavonoids, caffeic and rosmarinic acid, and triterpenoids.

History & Folklore In 1597, the herbalist John Gerard made this assessment: "Sweet marjoram is a remedy against cold diseases of the braine and head, being taken anyway to your best liking; put up into the nostrils it provokes sneezing, and draweth forth much baggage flegme; it easeth the toothache being chewed in the mouth."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Mainly used as a culinary herb, sweet marjoram is also medicinally valuable due to its stimulant and antispasmodic properties. Like oregano (*O. vulgare*, following entry), it treats flatulence, colic, and respiratory problems, but it appears to have a stronger effect on the nervous system than its wild cousin. Sweet marjoram is a good general tonic, helping to relieve anxiety, headaches, and insomnia. The herb is also thought to lower sexual drive.

Cautions Do not take as a medicine during pregnancy. Do not take sweet marjoram essential oil internally.

Origanum vulgare (Lamiaceae) Oregano, Wild Marjoram

Description Upright perennial herb growing to about 32 in (80 cm). Has square red stems, elliptical leaves, and clusters of deep pink flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Oregano is native to Europe and naturalized in the Middle East. The plant thrives in chalky soils close to the sea. It is gathered when in flower in summer.



Oregano's essential oil, well diluted, is a traditional remedy for toothache.